



DEVOTEES AT THE SABARIMALA TEMPLE

## The Big Four

The four Devaswom boards which administer the state's 3,000-odd temples

### Travancore (TDB)

TEMPLES **1,210**  
ANNUAL BUDGET **Rs 560 crore**  
EMPLOYEES **3,000**  
MEMBERS **3**

### Cochin (CDB)

TEMPLES **400**  
ANNUAL BUDGET **Rs 56 crore**  
EMPLOYEES **2,000**  
MEMBERS **7**

### Guruvayur (GDB)

TEMPLES **8**  
ANNUAL BUDGET **Rs 100 crore**  
EMPLOYEES **600**  
MEMBERS **9**

### Malabar (MDB)

TEMPLES: **1,340**  
ANNUAL BUDGET **Rs 128 crore**  
EMPLOYEES **6,000**  
MEMBERS **9**

Muslim and Christian groups too have come out in support of the Hindu organisations with a view that "believers should stand together irrespective of religion to oppose the atheist attempt to take control over places of worship". The BJP and other Hindu groups have for long been opposing the interference of "secular" political parties in temple affairs,

saying that the parties were after the riches of the TDB which has an annual revenue generation of about Rs 250 crore and assets worth hundreds of crores. The four Devaswom Boards in the state together have an annual budget exceeding Rs 1,000 crore and have more than 10,000 employees across more than 2,000 temples in the state.

What has angered Hindu groups is a clause in the proposed Bill which says that the Government will institute a judicial inquiry into any decision taken by the boards and empowers it to dismiss the boards in case of any irregularities. "This will end the autonomy of the boards and bring them under the Government," says Kummanam Rajasekharan of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad. Other controversial clauses include raising the TDB membership from the existing three to seven and entrusting appointments in the temples to the state Public Service Commission. According to the BJP, the move to raise the membership is to accommodate more members from the ruling coalition. Usually nominees from the



“ The Bill is an attempt to cleanse the TDB of rampant corruption. Not a single board has been free of corruption till date. ”

**G. SUDHAKARAN**

STATE COOPERATION MINISTER